

Ostrich

Struthio camelus

The largest living bird, the ostrich is immensely heavy and unable to fly. Standing more than 6½ ft (2 m) tall, ostriches are the tallest keen-sighted plains animals, except for giraffes. A bolting ostrich—reaching speeds of 45 mph (70 km/h)—alerts all prey species to danger.

Males attract females and repel rivals by making a deep boom. Akin to the roar of a lion, the “ohh-oooh-ooooooooo” can be heard 2 miles (3 km) away.

- ↔ 6–9 ft (1.7–2.7 m)
- ⚖ 220–353 lb (100–160 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Plants, insects
- 🏠 

W., E., and
Southern Africa



△ CHOOSING HER MATE

In the breeding season, a female ostrich bends her neck forward, flaps her wings backward, and makes a clapping noise when she selects a displaying male.

long legs and two-toed
feet adapted for sprinting



▽ DEFENSIVE MEASURES

Body arched, mouth holding tail but ready to bite, scale edges sharp and forbidding, and foot claws ready to scratch—all these form the armadillo lizard's excellent defense mechanism.

tail gripped in
powerful jaws to form
protective hoop



Cape cobra

Naja nivea

The Cape cobra prefers dry, scrubby habitats, where it hunts by day for small prey, such as colonial weaver bird eggs and nestlings. Like other cobras, it has fixed (not tilting) front fangs that inject nerve-disabling venom. After mating in early

spring, the female lays 10–20 eggs in midsummer, usually in a rodent burrow or termite nest. Young Cape cobras have a characteristic dark throat patch that fades with age.

◁ STANDING ITS GROUND

A threatened Cape cobra rears up, spreads its hood, gapes, and hisses. Predators include meerkats, snake eagles, and secretary birds.

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 5–7 lb (2–3 kg)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🌿 Rodents, reptiles, birds
- 🏠 
- 📍 Southern Africa